declare "Upendraji a socialist with greater ideological-moral values". Ironical words those, for the parting of ways leaves a jarring note in the long history of socialist politics of Bihar. If Nitish is seen as the tallest leader of Bihar's Luv-Kush bloc—the numerically significant Kurmis and Koeris (Kushwahas) in the state—Kushwaha, too, has laid claim to the same base, with less success.

When Nitish overturned 15 years of Lalu raj by decisively defeating the Rashtriya Janata Dal in 2005, much of his electoral success then was attributed to his seemingly unshakable base of Kurmi-Koeri voters with the Extremely Backward Castes grafted on top.

Since then, he has only consolidated his sway over those social blocs. Kushwaha, on the other hand, had a dream run in 2014 when his erstwhile party, the Rashtriya Lok Samata Party (RLSP), won all the three seats it contested in the Lok Sabha election as a BJP ally. But his personal base was proved to be shaky when he suffered a rout in the 2019 general election, which he contested as part of the RJD-led grand alliance, as well as the 2020 assembly polls, for which he allied with BSP and AIMIM. His party had to forfeit deposits in 94 out of the 99 seats it contested, losing all. That may not matter to the BJP, which was left friendless after Nitish's abrupt departure less than a year ago. Since then, it has won over Chirag Paswan, who brings a 5-6 per cent Paswan vote to the saffron kitty. "The BJP will be fine if Kushwaha comes on board and adds another 3 per cent votes," says a senior BJP leader in Bihar.

KUSHWAHA LOST HOPE WHEN NITISH STARTED PROJECTING TEJASHWI AND NOT HIM AS THE FUTURE LEADER OF BIHAR

Alliances will be crucial in Bihar, and Nitish and the RJD are well aware that they stand a firmer chance against the BJP's mighty electoral machine if they stay together and manage to restrict the election to a bipolar contest. For, the BJP gains when there is a triangular contest in the state, as was the case in the 2014 Lok Sabha election, when Nitish and Lalu contested separately and the saffron party swept the polls. This was the election in which Kushwaha's RLSP won three Lok Sabha seats in alliance with the BJP, earning him a berth in the Union cabinet in the first Modi-led government. This explains Nitish's eagerness to keep the Congress on the same page to ensure a minimum division of the secular vote in Bihar in the 2024 election. The BJP, too, is gathering allies. Chirag is already in, and they are evidently willing to forgive Kushwaha's past flip-flops—he had quit the NDA to join hands with Tejashwi Yadav on the eve of the 2019 Lok Sabha election.

Though the NDA may find it impossible to replicate its 2019 success—when it won 39 out of Bihar's 40 Lok Sabha seats—the BJP is keen that it does not fall too far behind. The political equation has changed drastically since then, with Nitish's JD(U)—which had won 16 out of the 17 seats it contested in 2019—now firmly in the opposition camp. Kushwaha will, therefore, come in useful, as he stakes a claim to Nitish's legacy, vote bank as well as socialist ideology.

Incidentally, this is Kushwaha's third separation from Nitish, his first political mentor. Though Kushwaha was elected to the Bihar assembly for the first time in 2000, Nitish made him leader of the opposition in March 2004. Kushwaha, however, lost the assembly polls in February and October 2005 and left the JD(U) to join the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) in 2006. He returned to the JD(U) before 2010 and was rewarded with a Rajya Sabha seat. He quit both the JD(U) and the RS seat in 2013, joining the BJP-led NDA a year later and becoming Union minister. That particular dalliance came to an end in December 2018 when Kushwaha quit the NDA to join the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD)-led grand alliance. A rout in the 2019 general election, and Kushwaha exited the grand alliance too.

He came back full circle to the JD(U) in March 2021—by merging his RLSP with Nitish's party. It was seen as a well-planned strategy to consolidate and strengthen the combined Kurmi and Kushwaha vote. Things soured soon after, however, when Nitish joined the mahagathbandhan and started projecting Tejashwi Yadav as the future leader of Bihar. Kushwaha, 63, found this difficult to stomach as he had for long fancied himself as Nitish's successor. The final straw was Nitish declaring the RJD scion and his deputy CM as the leader of the grand alliance for the 2025 Bihar assembly election. Hence Kushwaha's third departure from the JD(U). Is it for good? In politics, you never can say. ■



GUJARAT

A RUDE

By Jumana Shah

On February 4, a piece of news hit Gujarat's real estate developers like a tonne of bricks. The state government announced that it was doubling the circle rates relating to property, known as *jantri* rates locally, with immediate effect. Also called the Annual Statement of Rates (ASR), it's the minimum benchmark rate at which any property or land transaction can take place in the state. It determines the actual stamp duty paid to the government on every transaction at the mandated 6 per cent. All transactions beginning February 6 were to be done per the new *jantri* rates. Though realtors had loosely anticipated the revision—it was last done 12 years ago—the suddenness and magnitude of it shocked big and small players alike.

"It was a bolt from the blue," says developer Vijay Shah, who has been in the industry for close to four decades, adding that this kind of rate hike has never taken place before. CREDAI (Confed-